Functions of Liver

The main functions of liver include:

- Metabolism of carbohydrates, protein and fats
- The liver plays a major role in storage, activation and transport of many vitamins and minerals
- It helps in the formation and excretion of bile, conversion of ammonia to urea and metabolism of steroids.
- The liver converts carotene to retinol, a form of vitamin A. It synthesizes heparin which prevents coagulation of the blood.

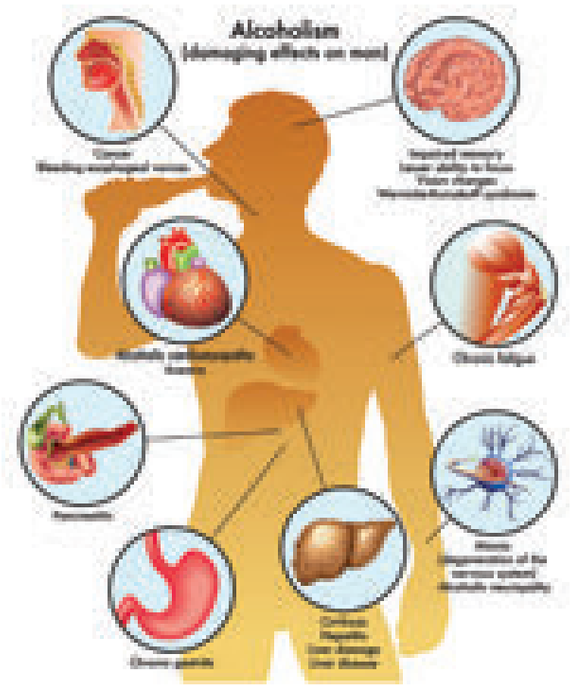
Any inflammation, infection or damage to liver hinders its functions and the liver becomes sluggish. Some of the common liver disorders are hepatitis, cirrhosis of liver, hepatic encephalopathy and liver cancer.

How does excess alcohol consumption causes liver disease?

Chronic abuse of alcohol has a hepatotoxic effect leading to malnutrition in an individual. Excess alcohol consumption can harm the liver causing inflammation and necrosis due to fat accumulation in the cells. A toxic byproduct of excessive alcohol intake is acetaldehyde which causes damage to the structure and function of the mitochondria in body cells, particularly in the liver. This reduces the normal functioning of liver causing severe vitamin and protein deficiency.

Excess alcohol intake can cause multiple complications such as:

- Most serious complication is vitamin and mineral deficiencies. Thiamine or vitamin B_1 deficiency is the most common vitamin deficiency and can cause Wernicke's encephalopathy. Severe vitamin A deficiency can also occur, leading to night blindness. In addition, deficiencies of folic acid, vitamins B_6, C, D, E and K are common. In regard to minerals, alcoholics may suffer from calcium, magnesium, phosphate and zinc deficiency.
- Protein deficiency in alcoholics can cause encephalopathy and result in coma
- Clotting defects can occur. This precipitates excess bleeding
- Portal hypertension resulting in ruptured varices and ascites.
- It can also affect kidney, heart and the blood vessels



8.2.1 HEPATITIS

Diseases of the liver can be acute or chronic, inherited or acquired. Hepatitis is an inflammation of liver. It is classified as follows:

1. Acute Viral Hepatitis
2. Chronic Hepatitis



Hepar' is the Greek term for liver. Liver related medical terms actually start with 'hepatic or hepato'. According to Greeks, the liver is the organ which is closest to divine presence as it is considered a home of all emotions

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